



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS

Mindfulness on the Mats™

Instructor Resource Pack

Quick Reference · Parent Handout · Troubleshooting · Certificates · Glossary

Your companion guide for every class. Print and keep at the front desk.

MOTM SUBSCRIPTION — INSTRUCTOR RESOURCE PACK

What's in This Pack

Quick Reference Guide: One-page cheat sheet — micro-scripts and on-the-mat challenges for all 4 modules.

Parent & Student Handout: "The Warrior's Edge" — print and send home or post in your waiting area.

Instructor Troubleshooting Guide: How to handle giggles, skeptics, sleepers, and fidgeters.

Certificates of Completion: Two versions — Standard and Young Warrior — ready to print and personalize.

Glossary of the Mindful Warrior: Key terms to use with students and parents.

References: Academic citations for the science behind the curriculum.

Quick Reference Guide

Instructor's Cheat Sheet — Print and Keep on Hand

SAFETY FIRST

The "Out": Always remind students: "If at any point this exercise becomes too uncomfortable, please stop or take a break."

Trauma-Informed: Remember that looking inward can be triggering for some students; allow them to keep their eyes open or change position if needed.

Module	Micro-Script (Meditation Stance)	On-the-Mat Challenges (During Training)
I — BREATH Grounding & Energy	• "Place one hand on your stomach. Inhale slowly through your nose and feel your hand rise." • "Notice where your breath begins and ends." • "Make your exhale longer than your inhale."	• "Stop! Check your breath. Are you holding it?" • "Does your breath move with your movements?" • "Use your breath to reset before this next round."
II — BODY Structure & Tension	• "Scan your body for tension. Check your jaw, your shoulders, your fists." • "Feel your feet connecting to the mat. Sink your weight down." • "If you find tension, use your exhale to let it drop away."	• "Pause. Where is your weight distributed right now? Are you off-center?" • "Identify one muscle group you are tensing that doesn't need to be tense." • "Feel the difference: speed with tension vs. speed with relaxation."
III — MIND Zanshin & Mushin	• "Imagine your mind has a 'guard.' Watch thoughts approach." • "Don't grapple with the thoughts. Let them pass by like a sparring partner walking past." • "If you get distracted, gently bring your guard back to center."	• "You just made a mistake. Did your mind stay there, or move to the next technique?" • "Expand your awareness. Can you see your opponent's whole body, not just their hands?" • "Reset to neutral. Clear the last round from your head."
IV — SPIRIT Flow & Purpose	• "Recall a time you felt unstoppable or perfectly in sync." • "Breathe that focus into your chest. Send that purpose into your limbs." • "Connect to your 'Why'. Why are you training today?"	• "Don't think. Just do. Move on intuition." • "Trust your training. Let your body take over." • "Find the flow — where the rest of the room disappears."

Parent & Student Handout: The Warrior's Edge

Print and send home, post in your waiting area, or share digitally.

What is Mindfulness on the Mats™?

You might hear the word "mindfulness" and think of yoga studios or sitting quietly in a room. However, mindfulness is not new to the martial arts. Mindfulness on the Mats™ (MOTM) is a holistic curriculum designed to help martial artists and athletes improve their mental game. It teaches students how to use quality mindfulness instruction to support their growth and performance in the dojo.

Why Bring Mindfulness to the Dojo?

- **Performance:** Just as you notice when you overextend a physical strike, mindfulness helps you notice when your mind overextends and pulls you off center.
- **Awareness (Zanshin):** We train to notice what is happening inside us and outside us. Failure to pay attention can mean defeat.
- **Emotional Control:** Breathing and mental focus tools help students ground themselves when they feel angry, hyper, hurt, or frustrated.
- **Science-Backed:** Research shows that mindfulness can literally change brain activity and structure — strengthening the decision-making center and calming the panic response.



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS

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The Four Pillars of the Mindful Warrior

1. BREATH

Breathing is the keystone of focus and energy. By synchronizing breath with movement, students increase their power and ability to remain calm under pressure.

2. BODY

We practice scanning for tension and ensuring our physical structure is aligned and grounded — because martial artists must know where every part of their body is in space.

3. MIND

We explore Mushin ("No Mind"), a state where the mind is not fixated on one thought or fear. This flexibility allows the warrior to react instantly.

4. SPIRIT

This module focuses on the state of "flow" — when the rest of the world disappears and you are totally present in the here and now, moving with intuition.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Is this religious?

A: No. While aspects of mindfulness originate from ancient Buddhist practices, these techniques are used today in entirely secular settings: schools, the military, veterans programs, and corporate boardrooms. There is no religious content in this curriculum.

Q: Is this therapy?

A: No. The MOTM curriculum is educational in nature only. While mindfulness has therapeutic effects, this program is designed for coaching and performance, not psychotherapy.

Instructor Troubleshooting Guide

Common student reactions — and exactly what to do.

1. "The Giggles"

The Issue: Students (especially children or teens) giggle when asked to close their eyes or breathe deeply.

The Fix: Do not scold them. Giggling is often a release of nervous energy or a defense mechanism against feeling vulnerable.

What to Say: *""It's okay to giggle; that's just energy leaving the body. Let it out, smile, and then bring your focus back to your breath.""*

2. "The Skeptic"

The Issue: A student feels this is "boring" or "not real fighting."

The Fix: Pivot to the science. Avoid "spiritual" language and use "performance" language.

What to Say: *""This isn't just relaxing. We are thickening the prefrontal cortex so you don't freeze in a real fight. This is brain conditioning.""*

3. "The Sleeper"

The Issue: A student falls asleep during a script.

The Fix: This usually means the student is exhausted or feels very safe in your dojo. Gently wake them at the end.

What to Say: *""You clearly needed that rest, but next time try to keep the mind awake while the body rests.""*

4. "The Fidgeter"

The Issue: A student cannot sit still for 60 seconds.

The Fix: Allow them to stand in a horse stance or lie down. Some nervous systems process stillness better when muscles are engaged (horse stance) or fully supported (lying down).

What to Say: *""No specific script needed — simply offer the alternative position and proceed.""*

Certificates of Completion

Two versions below. Print on cardstock (cream or white) for best results.

Option 1: Standard Certificate (Teens & Adults)

CERTIFICATE OF ACHIEVEMENT

PRESENTED TO

For the successful completion of the
Mindfulness on the Mats™ Curriculum

This student has demonstrated dedication to the mental aspects of the martial arts,
completing training in the four pillars of the Mindful Warrior:

BREATH · BODY · MIND · SPIRIT

By cultivating Zanshin (Awareness) and Mushin (A Flexible Mind),
you have taken the next step in training your spirit as well as your body.

Date: _____

Dojo Instructor

Dr. Joseph Assouline, PsyD
Founder, Mindfulness on the Mats™

MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS™

Option 2: Young Warrior Certificate (Ages 3–11)**MINDFUL WARRIOR AWARD**

THIS AWARD IS GIVEN TO

Congratulations!

You have learned to control your Breath, listen to your Body,
focus your Mind, and find your Spirit.

**You have shown that a true martial artist is
strong on the outside and calm on the inside.**

You have learned to bring yourself back to the center, non-judgmentally.

Keep Training Mindfully!

Date: _____

Coach / Instructor

Implementation Tips:

- Print on heavier cardstock (cream or white) to make the achievement feel tangible.
- Hand these out at the end of class or during belt testing to associate mental training with physical advancement.
- Place the MOTM logo in the bottom center using the logo file provided in your subscription welcome email.

Glossary of the Mindful Warrior

Flow State

A mental state where a person performing an activity is fully immersed in a feeling of energized focus; action and awareness merge.

Kiai

A shout used in martial arts to coordinate breath with movement and spirit.

Mindfulness

Noticing thoughts, feelings, and body sensations in the present moment without getting caught up in them.

Mushin (No Mind)

A mind not fixated on any single thought or emotion, allowing for flexible, intuitive reaction. From Japanese: "no mind" or "without mind."

Neuroplasticity

The brain's ability to reorganize itself by forming new neural connections; the concept that the brain changes structure based on experience.

Proprioception

The body's ability to sense its location, movements, and actions; the "sixth sense" of body position. Critical for martial arts technique.

Zanshin

Total awareness of oneself and one's surroundings; a state of sustained alertness that allows for effective reaction to attackers and opponents.



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS

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